

Srinath Mahankali

Education

Massachusetts Institute Of Technology

Candidate for Bachelors in AI and Decision Making; GPA 4.9/5.0

September 2021 - February 2025

- Selected Graduate-Level Coursework: Advanced Sensorimotor Learning, Large Language Models, Computer Vision, Statistical Reinforcement Learning, Machine Learning, Robotic Manipulation

Work Experience

Eka Robotics

March 2025 - Present

Research Engineer

- Second engineer at a leading dexterous robotic manipulation startup.
- Spearheaded technical demos for coming out of stealth, implementing vision capabilities for robotic systems, enabling robots to handle cluttered environments, and training policies for contact-rich manipulation tasks such as screwing in lightbulbs.

Research Experience

Improbable AI Lab, CSAIL, MIT

June 2022 - Present

Undergraduate Researcher | Advisor: Prof. Pulkit Agrawal

- Developing a new algorithm for reinforcement learning agents to explore their environment efficiently and learn useful skills. Investigated the impact of various intrinsic rewards on exploration. Showed that randomly choosing intrinsic reward functions can lead to better exploration than novelty-based intrinsic rewards.
- Studying the use of a new algorithm, extrinsic-intrinsic policy optimization, for locomotion. Demonstrated that this algorithm improved performance while minimizing energy consumption on a real quadruped.

Selected Research Papers

- Mahankali, Srinath**, Zhang-Wei Hong, Ayush Sekhari, Alexander Rakhlin, Pulkit Agrawal. [Random Latent Exploration for Deep Reinforcement Learning](#). International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML) 2024.
- Mahankali, Srinath**, Chi-Chang Lee, Gabriel B. Margolis, Zhang-Wei Hong, Pulkit Agrawal. [Maximizing Quadruped Velocity by Minimizing Energy](#). International Conference on Robotics and Automation (ICRA) 2024.
- Mahankali, Srinath**, Zhang-Wei Hong, Pulkit Agrawal. [Does Novelty-Based Exploration Maximize Novelty?](#)
- Ghosal, Promit, **Srinath Mahankali**, and Yihang Sun. [Randomly Initialized One-Layer Neural Networks Make Data Linearly Separable](#). arXiv preprint arXiv:2205.11716 (2022).

Awards & Honors

- 2025 CRA Outstanding Undergraduate Researcher Award - Runner Up
- 2024 Goldwater Scholarship Winner
- Regeneron Science Talent Search 2021: Scholar (Top 300) Award
- Mathematical Association of America 2021: Qualified for USAMO

Leadership Experience

Captain, New York City Math Team

September 2020 - June 2021

- Recruited 130+ members, strategized for national competitions, and created curriculum for weekly practice
- Team Awards: 1st Place at Princeton University Mathematics Competition 2020 (held in 2021), 2nd Place at American Regions Mathematics League 2021, 3rd Place at Harvard-MIT Mathematics Tournament 2021

Skills

- Software: Python, JAX, PyTorch, ROS